

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

The Cuban Missile Crisis — Nuclear Brinkmanship and Diplomatic Resolution

US.70 — Describe the relationship between Cuba and the United States, including the Bay of Pigs Invasion and Cuban Missile Crisis.

TEACHER EDITION — scoring guide and expected evidence. Not for student distribution.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Directions. Read the following three primary source excerpts and respond to the prompt below. Apply HIPP analysis to at least two documents and construct an argument.

The sources

Document A

President John F. Kennedy, Television and Radio Address on Cuba, October 22, 1962 — U.S. government document, available through the John F. Kennedy Presidential Library (National Archives)

“The Soviet Union has taken a new and reckless step in raising the threat of thermonuclear war. Acting in the defense of our own security and of the entire Western Hemisphere, and under the authority entrusted to me by the Constitution as endorsed by the resolution of the Congress, I have directed that the following initial steps be taken immediately. First: To halt this offensive buildup, a strict quarantine on all offensive military equipment under shipment to Cuba is being initiated.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document B

Premier Nikita Khrushchev, Letter to President Kennedy, October 26, 1962 — declassified Soviet-American diplomatic correspondence, available through the National Security Archive at George Washington University (National Archives)

“If there is no intention to doom the world to the catastrophe of thermonuclear war, then let us not only relax the forces pulling on the ends of the rope, let us take measures to untie that knot. We are ready for this... I have participated in two wars and know that war ends when it has rolled through cities and villages, everywhere sowing death and destruction. For such is the logic of war. If people do not display wisdom, they will clash like blind moles and then mutual annihilation will commence.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document C

President John F. Kennedy, Letter to Premier Khrushchev, October 27, 1962 — declassified diplomatic correspondence, available through the John F. Kennedy Presidential Library (National Archives)

“The first thing that needs to be done, however, is for work to cease on offensive missile bases in Cuba and for all weapons systems in Cuba capable of offensive use to be rendered inoperable, under effective United Nations arrangements. Assuming this is done promptly, I have given my representatives in New York instructions that will permit them to work out this week end... an arrangement for a permanent solution to the Cuban problem.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT C

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

Using all three documents and your knowledge of the Cuban Missile Crisis (US.66), construct an argument analyzing the diplomatic resolution of the Crisis as a case study in nuclear deterrence and crisis management. Apply HIPP analysis to at least two documents and

1. what Kennedy's and Khrushchev's rhetoric reveals about the constraints and rationality of nuclear deterrence
2. what the episode reveals about the difference between public and private diplomacy in nuclear crises

Plan your answer

Your claim	
------------	--

Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Document C		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

Scoring guide

Pts	6-point scale
6	Exemplary. Precise, arguable thesis on nuclear deterrence and crisis resolution. Full HIPP on at least two documents (all four elements, historically accurate). Outside evidence (minimum 3 specific facts). Addresses all three prompt components: deterrence logic, post-crisis arms control, public/private diplomacy distinction. Synthesizes all three documents to show the structure of nuclear brinkmanship.
5	Advanced. Clear thesis. Full HIPP on two documents. Two outside evidence points. Addresses two of three prompt components.
4	Proficient. Arguable thesis. HIPP partially applied to two documents. One outside evidence fact. Addresses two prompt components.
3	Adequate. General thesis. Analyzes at least two documents. Some outside knowledge.
2	Developing. Basic claim. References documents, mostly summary. Minimal outside evidence.
1	Beginning. Attempts a response without substantive analysis.
0	No response or off-topic.

Expected evidence and document analysis. DOCUMENT ANALYSIS EXPECTATIONS: Document A HIPP — 'quarantine' vs. 'blockade' terminology as legal/political calculation; the simultaneous public/Soviet audience. Document B HIPP — Khrushchev's 'moles' metaphor as emotional authenticity contrasting with his public bluster; the Oct. 26 letter as the opening of the resolution path. Document C HIPP — Kennedy's conditional language as coercive bargaining; 'permanent solution to the Cuban problem' as face-saving vagueness. KEY EVIDENCE EXPECTED: ExComm (13 members, 13 days); quarantine announced Oct. 22; Khrushchev Oct. 26 and Oct. 27 letters (two different letters on Oct. 27 complicating resolution); U-2 shootdown Oct. 27; B-59 submarine incident; secret Turkey missile deal; hotline (June 1963); Limited Test Ban Treaty (Aug. 1963); SALT I (1972).

Sourcing. Every document above carries its own citation as written in the item record. Verify each against the holding institution before classroom use — an unsourced primary source is worse than a missing one.

History Hack · TroopToTeacher Technologies. Tennessee Academic Standards 2027-28. classroom-formative · pre-field-test — this activity has not been field-tested and its scoring guide is not calibrated.